

Department of Economics
Johns Hopkins University
Baltimore, MD 21218
dedwar65@jh.edu

December 21, 2025

Search Committee
Department of Economics
Mount Holyoke College
South Hadley, MA
USA

Dear Members of the Search Committee,

I am writing to apply for the Visiting Assistant Professor position in Economics at Mount Holyoke College. I am a Ph.D. candidate in Economics at Johns Hopkins University, advised by Professors Christopher D. Carroll, Nicholas W. Papageorge, and Stelios Fourakis, and I expect to receive my degree in May 2026. My research fields are macroeconomics, wealth and income dynamics, and computational economics.

My research agenda focuses on understanding the determinants of wealth inequality and the mechanisms through which heterogeneity in returns to wealth shapes aggregate outcomes. In my job-market paper, I estimate the degree of heterogeneity in individual portfolio returns using micro-data from the Survey of Consumer Finances and simulate a structural model in which households face idiosyncratic return risk. I show that allowing for persistent heterogeneity in returns substantially improves the model's ability to match the empirical distribution of wealth, offering a tractable way to connect micro-level return dispersion to macroeconomic inequality.

In a second project, I use the Health and Retirement Study to examine the relationship between interpersonal trust and portfolio performance. Building on the literature that finds a hump-shaped relationship between trust and income, I show that a similar relationship holds for individual returns to wealth measured in the HRS data, highlighting a behavioral channel through which social attitudes shape saving and investment outcomes. This work also provides new estimates of the persistent component of returns to net worth, which motivate the calibration of heterogeneity in my structural model.

Mount Holyoke College is a particularly appealing environment for me as a visiting faculty member. The department's emphasis on rigorous undergraduate training, inclusive pedagogy, and close faculty-student engagement aligns closely with my own approach to teaching economics. I am especially drawn to Mount Holyoke's mission as a leading liberal arts institution dedicated to intellectual curiosity, academic excellence, and the education of students from diverse backgrounds.

Teaching. I have experience teaching and supporting courses in *Principles of Macroeconomics*, *Intermediate Macroeconomic Theory*, and applied macroeconomic electives. My teaching philosophy emphasizes clarity, economic intuition, and careful scaffolding of quantitative concepts. In a liberal arts setting, I focus on helping students connect formal models to real economic questions, using data and empirical examples to motivate theory. I would be well prepared to teach introductory and intermediate economics courses and to contribute meaningfully to Mount Holyoke's undergraduate

curriculum during the visiting appointment.

I would be enthusiastic about contributing to the intellectual life of the Economics Department and supporting its teaching mission during my time at Mount Holyoke College.

Thank you very much for your time and consideration. I would welcome the opportunity to discuss my application further.

Sincerely,

Decory Edwards